

Pairing a modest gift with a donation could solve this problem.

4. Start a new holiday tradition

This year I'm going to help my older daughter choose a recipient of a charitable gift, something I'd like to continue with my kids as they grow. I think we'll appreciate these memories as fondly as we'd remember an annual holiday tea at Chicago's The Drake hotel (now \$136 for two) or tickets to *The Nutcracker*.

For your extended family, if everyone's into it, you could even replace the annual gift exchange with charitable donations.

5. Make rules

At our house, anytime we win money, it goes into our daughters' college fund. Not the best educational planning, I admit, but it's better than nothing. You could apply the same rule to charity. Or, if you receive an annual bonus at the end of the year, earmark a portion of it for philanthropy.

6. Clean house

Prosperous families need to streamline annually anyway to avoid turning their home into a junk warehouse.

A good way to kick off the holiday season is a clean-out day where everyone—including and especially the kids—chooses items to either donate directly to a charity shop or to sell to raise money for a donation.

My husband practices a version of this strategy throughout the year. Whenever he sells something online, the money goes to his PayPal account. Rather than bothering to have PayPal cut him a check, he transfers the proceeds at the end of the year to his favorite charity.

7. Develop a just-for-charity income stream

So you put ads on your blog and—if you're like me—are depressed by the rate at which the proceeds trickle in. The whole thing might turn from a downer to a source of cheer if you watch your earnings oh-so-gradually grow over the course of the year, and then donate it all to a worthy charity.

Kids, too, can find ways to earn a little money for charity through crafts or other business endeavors.

8. Take advantage of matching gifts

Whatever you can scrape together can go farther if your employer matches employee donations.